

1.1 RATIONALE

This specification has been designed to enable candidates to have the opportunity to study psychology at an introductory level, yet also to gain enough insight into the subject to enable them to complete the course with a rounded knowledge of the approaches, processes and issues that have been chosen to illustrate it at GCSE level. The specification includes the requirement that candidates should carry out an internally assessed task involving a more detailed investigation to illustrate an aspect of the psychology that they study during the course.

The specification is built upon the understanding that psychological knowledge could be treated as being made up of a number of different approaches. What actually constitutes these approaches can stimulate endless debate; for the purposes of this specification, they include six approaches, each illustrated by two topic areas.

The approaches are:

- Social Psychology;
- Behavioural Psychology;
- Developmental Psychology;
- Individual Differentiation;
- Cognitive Psychology;
- Bio-psychology.

The material within the topic areas associated with the individual approaches should enable candidates to understand how particular methodologies, cultural constraints and ethical considerations can bring influence to bear upon the development of knowledge within each approach. The topic areas also provide an opportunity for the consideration of the impact of psychology on everyday life by looking at the applications of psychology. Therefore the specification has a number of underlying processes and issues which should be considered as an integral part of the material outlined in each topic area. This allows for the development of psychological skills as well as the learning of psychological knowledge.

OCR has taken great care in the preparation of this specification and assessment materials to avoid bias of any kind.